

It's come to pass now - the computer is becoming the media hub of most urban households. The wide variety of open-platform architectures developed around the world has resulted in the spawning of a myriad of formats for storing and methods for manipulating data.

Entertainment has always been one of the catalysts of innovation in technology. Both software and hardware developments have focused on delivering content quicker and in a crisp fashion. The result is that you have an overwhelming number of tools and utilities for each task. Choosing the best among these is now also becoming a problem. Factors such as compatibility with your existing setup and ease of availability with regard to upgrades become important and defining.

Some video players, codecs, and converters are freely available on the Internet. Many of these are cross-platform. We review some of the best free software that can play your videos irrespective of file format and encode the files in a specific format, codec packs that can take on any video format you dish out, and finally, editing and movie processing software that help you make that perfect home video - or who knows: even a Hollywood blockbuster like <The Blair Witch Project>!

4.2 Video Players

One of the essentials in any computer is a video player. With the large number of formats available, it has become difficult to go hunting for the codecs that will help play your video on your existing media players. You could keep downloading the codecs, yet newer ones keep sprouting. The need of the hour is open source, cross-platform players that support as many formats as possible, while being compact enough to be downloaded and easy to load.

The other important prerequisite is that the player interface be clean and intuitive. In addition to this, the player must also be